

Chapter 1: Rama—Prince and Principle

Summary:

Rama, the essence of the Vedas, is a sacred text that has inspired the poetic imagination of every language and country. It is the guardian deity of Hindus and is borne by the bodies in which they dwell and the buildings in which those bodies dwell. The Ramayana, the epic that deals with the story of the Rama incarnation, is reverently recited by people of all varieties of equipment, including scholars, ignoramus, millionaires, and paupers.

The name Rama glorified by the Ramayana cleanses all evil and transforms the sinner. The ocean of milk and the almighty Lord share much in common, as a sea without water is unreal and a being without "Rama" is without existence. The name of each canto (kanda) given by Valmiki (son of Prachetas), the great poet who composed the epic, Kanda means water or sugar cane.

The story of Rama meanders through many curves and twists, but the sweetness of compassion (karuna), tenderness, and pity persists throughout the narrative. The main undercurrent is the love of dharma and the compassion it fosters. The Ramayana should be read not as a record of a human career but as the narrative of the advent and activities of an incarnation of God (Avatar).

The study of history must enrich life and make it meaningful and worthwhile, rather than catering to the appetite for paltry facts and petty ideas. The spiritual seeker should yearn to imbibe the expression of tenderness, pity, and compassion with which the Ramayana is saturated, paying no heed to other subjects.

Emperor Parikshith sought guidance from sage Suka, who helped him solve a riddle he had been struggling with. Suka's careful study of his forefathers' lives, from the great Manu to his grandfathers and father, revealed the presence of sages in their histories.

Chapter 13: Entering into Exile

Summary:

In Chapter 13, the emperor, Dasaratha, is grieving over the loss of his beloved son Rama. The minister, Kaika, and Sita come to talk with him, and Rama speaks words of soothing love. Dasaratha's grief is immense, and he hugs Rama tightly. Lakshmana, however, is angry and rages at her words. Rama pleads for his father to be courageous and give up the delusion that made him dote on him.

Dasaratha, knowing Rama as a master of morality and a strict adherent of these codes, decides to take Rama into exile. He tells Sita about the hardships of forest life and suggests that she stay back with her parents-in-law or with her own parents. Sita, however, refuses, stating that she longs for the service of Rama and the joy of fulfillment it brings. She asks her husband to accept her decision and leave the forest.

The wives of royal ministers and preceptors gather around Sita, who describes the hardships of forest life. Kaika, the court preceptor's spouse, offers hermit's robes and rosaries to dissuade her. She tells Rama that the emperor holds her dear and is unwilling to let him go. She also warns him that his affection for her clouded the righteousness of the course. Rama agrees to either court infamy and dishonour and stay to rule over the empire or leave for the forest and bring eternal glory to the Ikshvaku dynasty.

Dasharatha is overcome with grief and refuses to accept Kaika's suggestion. He wound one of the fibre robes around himself and gave the other to Sita. She is embarrassed by the short and narrow robes, but Rama consoles her and gives her courage.

In the end, the emperor is relieved to see his father's helplessness and decides to leave. Sita, however, is left to ponder the consequences of her decision and the impact it will have on the empire. The story highlights the importance of self-control, compassion, and the power of love in overcoming adversity and achieving happiness.

Chapter 17: The Brothers Meet

Summary:

Chapter 17 of the epic story revolves around Bharatha and Satrugna, brothers who decide to go to Rama to see the Lord. They meet with the ministers, royal preceptor, and leading citizens of the capital, eager to hear their decision. Bharatha is hesitant to join the chariot, as he believes his reign would bring harm to the people and be immoral. He is also concerned about the consequences of his actions, as he has done mountains of wrong in ascending the throne that is not rightfully mine.

Bharatha's mother's evil design has turned into an agonizing headache for him, and he has obtained permission from Kausalya and Sumitra to proceed at dawn tomorrow to Rama. He believes that the sight of Rama will cool his heart and cure his agony. The chief of the elders asks for permission to go to Rama, and others respond with prayers for their own journey.

The news spreads throughout the city, and no one can dissuade others from proceeding to Rama. Kausalya and Sumitra also set out on the journey with their maids. Kaika, overcome with repentance for her errors and sins, communicates with Kausalya and prays for permission to join the queens in attempting to persuade Rama to return to Ayodhya. Kausalya sends word for Kaika to join her.

Bharatha is informed that the entire city is on the move, and Vedic scholars are directed to continue reciting auspicious hymns and taking ceremonial requisites for the ritual worship of fire. The army, with its force of chariotry, elephantry, cavalry, and infantry, gets ready to march. Vedic scholars are directed to keep on reciting auspicious hymns and bring with them the ceremonial requisites for the ritual worship of fire.

Bharatha orders everyone to occupy their chariot or vehicle, and Bharatha and Satrugna walk by its side, barefooted. Kausalya, who cannot tolerate this, asks Bharatha to sit in the chariot for some time. Bharatha replies that it is only to make amends for the sins he is burdened with and that it is highly wrong for him to ride in a chariot.

The royal preceptor, Vasishtha, and his consort Arundathi, who were seated in the preceding chariot, stop their vehicle and pray to Bharatha to sit in their chariot. Bharatha remains steadfast in his vow to act as Rama's charioteer until he receives the opportunity to do so.

Chapter 20: Panchavati

Summary:

In Chapter 20 of the Mahabharata, Rama and Lakshmana are sent to build a cottage in Panchavati on the Godavari. Lakshmana is shocked by the order and asks Rama what he has done to deserve it. Rama explains that Lakshmana's only possession is Sita and Rama, and his duty is to follow Rama's command. Lakshmana supplicates, saying that his wish is Rama's will, not his own.

Rama consoles Lakshmana, showing him that his heart is highly sanctified and that his intentions are innocent and elevating. He then takes Sita and Rama with him to erect the hut, and they are delighted at the purity of his devotion and genuineness of service. They recollect the depth of his faith and devotion, and Sita often confesses to Rama that life in the forest was even more delightful than life at Ayodhya because a brother like Lakshmana was accompanying them and serving Rama.

The three spend their days happily in the cottage, where news of Sri Rama making the Panchavati his home spread far and wide. Every day, groups of ascetics trekked there to offer their homage and bring their pupils with them. They had their fill of the sight (darshan) of the Lord and had the great good fortune of speaking to Rama and being spoken to by Him.

Some ascetics came to Rama with questions to solve doubts and seek clarification on their ascetic practices. Since Rama was master of all dharmas, they derived the fullest satisfaction from His answers and directives. Each one was filled with joyous contentment.

Questions are generally classified into four grades: trivial, low, passable, and praiseworthy. Trivial questions are raised to drag another into controversy and later to inflict a humiliating defeat, while low questions demonstrate one's cleverness and skill. Passable questions announce the intellectual equipment and reasoning faculty of the questioner, while praiseworthy questions ask with the sincere desire to remove one's doubts.

Rama and Lakshmana are filled with delight when they see the ascetics and admiration when they listen to the ideals propounded by Rama. They exclaim, "O master supreme!" and are grateful for the blessings they have received from Rama. Some ascetics leave Rama's presence unwillingly, gathered fruits and tubers, and watched out for additional chances of His sight.

Chapter 25: The Bridge

Summary:

In Chapter 25, Rama asks a messenger, Suka, how to cross the sea. Many monkeys suggest methods and approaches, but Vibhishana suggests that the ocean is the family 'preceptor' of Rama's line. A messenger sent by Ravana is seen by Vibhishana, who is bound and taken to Sugriva. Sugriva orders his limbs to be cut off, but Vibhishana refuses to cut off his nose and ears. Lakshmana, the messenger's master, warns Ravana to change his heart and fall at Rama's feet.

Suka, the messenger, recounts the events and Rama's majestic charm to Ravana. Ravana questions his brother Vibhishana and how he fared, stating that his days are numbered and death will swallow him soon. Ravana then asks Suka about their camp and their military might and adamant resolve. Suka tells Ravana about the monkey armies, which are a galaxy of heroic warriors with immense stature and strength. They are determined to build a causeway of stones and succeed in their venture, and they are fearful of Rama's presence.

Ravana's reaction to the spy's and messenger's report is wild laughter. He criticizes Vibhishana for extolling the strength and heroism of mere monkeys and believes that he has heard enough of the power and might of Sugriva. Suka, the messenger, watches Ravana's heroics and bewails the lack of intelligence exhibited by Ravana.

Ravana opens the envelope containing Lakshmana's missive and compares it to a partridge, afraid of the sky falling upon its young fledglings. He compares the anchorites and ritual-ridden priests to a partridge, fearing the sky would fall and kill birds. Suka, the messenger, interrupts with the truth: Rama is tenderhearted and compassionate, and if only Rama would approach him, he would take Rama under his protection and guard him from harm.

In summary, Rama's journey to cross the sea is a complex and challenging journey, with various monkeys and their superior military skills. The story highlights the importance of understanding and respecting the power and wisdom of the monkeys, as well as the potential dangers and rewards of approaching Rama.

Chapter 29: Happy Ayodhya

Summary:

In Chapter 29, Rama and Sita take an aerial cart to Ayodhya, where they witness the victory of Lakshmana, a monkey who overpowered Meghanada. They then visit the holy sages and pay reverence to them. Rama then reaches the Dandaka Forest and offers prostrations to the sages at the Chitrakuta Hill. He also shows Sita the city of Kishkindha and the sacred rivers, the Yamuna and the Ganga, and worships them in her mind.

The chieftain of the Nishada tribe, Guha, yearns for Rama's return and falls flat on the ground in gratitude. The chariot lands at the very place where Guha falls at Rama's feet, and they bathe in the sacred river and ask Guha to bring a ferryboat to cross the Ganga. The aerial chariot is sent back to its original owner.

Rama commissioned Hanuman to change himself into a brahmin and go to Ayodhya to tell Bharatha the news about Rama and others. Hanuman leaves immediately, and Rama, Sita, Lakshmana, and all who had come with him move into the hermitage of Bharadwaja. Bharatha finds the residents of Ayodhya lean and famished, despondent, and depressed, as

they have not relished food or drink during Rama's absence.

Hanuman brings the news to Bharatha, who is filled with joy and gratitude. He tells Bharatha that Rama has achieved victory over all enemies and is near Ayodhya. Bharatha asks Hanuman how he can express his gratitude and what he will do for him in return. Hanuman is struck by Bharatha's devotion and dedication, and he falls at his feet to demonstrate his admiration.

Bharatha is amazed by Rama's achievements and the fact that he is the only brother in the world who is pure of heart and sharp of intellect. He is filled with virtues and is eager to see Rama soon.

In conclusion, Rama and Sita are on a journey to Ayodhya, where they witness the victory of Lakshmana and learn about his life and achievements. The story highlights the importance of friendship, love, and the sacrifices made by those who support each other in their journey.